“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 8

An Account of the Vaiṣṇavas’ Command to Compose the Book

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 I worship Lord Caitanya-deva, by whose will even this dull fool has suddenly been set to dance so wondrously on the stage of writing.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Gauracandra! Glory, glory to Nityānanda, full of the highest bliss!

3 Glory, glory to Advaita Ācārya, glory to the all-merciful! Glory, glory to the noble-hearted Gadādhara Paṇḍita!

4 Glory, glory to Śrīvāsa and to all the devotees! Bowing low, I worship the feet of them all.

5 By remembering them the mute become poets, the lame cross mountains and the blind see the stars.

6 The learning of scholars who do not accept all this is no more than the croaking of frogs.

7 Whoever practises devotion to Kṛṣṇa yet does not accept all this receives no mercy from Kṛṣṇa and reaches no goal.[2]

8 Long ago Jarāsandha and other kings followed the Vedic dharma and worshipped Viṣṇu.

9 But they did not accept Kṛṣṇa, and so we regard them as demons; and whoever does not accept Caitanya, we know, is a demon just the same.[3]

10 "If they do not accept Me, all people will be lost." For this reason the Lord, His heart melting with mercy, accepted sannyāsa.

11 "Even if they bow to Me thinking Me an ordinary sannyāsī, their misery will be cut away and they will find deliverance."[4]

12 Whoever does not worship Caitanya, so full of mercy, is counted among the asuras, even if he is the greatest of men.[5]

13 Therefore, with arms upraised, I say again: give up false argument and worship Caitanya and Nityānanda!

14 But a logician may say: "Logic is the proof. Whatever the science of logic establishes is what deserves worship."

15 Then weigh the mercy of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya; weigh it well, and your heart will be struck with wonder.[6]

16 One may hear and chant for many births, and still not obtain the treasure of love for Kṛṣṇa's feet.[7]

17 "Liberation is easily won through knowledge, and enjoyment through the merit of sacrifices and other pious works; but devotion to Hari is hard to attain even by thousands of spiritual practices." (Tantra; also Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.1.36)[8]

18 Kṛṣṇa may slip away from a devotee by giving him enjoyment or liberation, but devotion He never gives: He keeps it hidden.[9]

19 (Śukadeva said:) "O King, Mukunda is the master and guru of you Pāṇḍavas and of the Yadus; He is your worshipped Deity, your dearest friend and the head of your family, and at times He even becomes your servant. So it is, dear one; yet to those who worship Him the Lord gives liberation, but bhakti-yoga He never gives." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.6.18)[10]

20 Such love Śrī Caitanya gave everywhere, even to Jagāi and Mādhāi — what then of others?[11]

21 The independent Lord gave away prema, that hidden storehouse, to anyone at all, and made no distinctions.

22 See it even today: whoever takes the name of Caitanya is overwhelmed with love for Kṛṣṇa, his body thrilling and his eyes streaming with tears.[12]

23 At the name "Nityānanda" love for Kṛṣṇa awakens; every limb is shaken, and a Gaṅgā of tears flows.

24 The name of Kṛṣṇa takes account of offences: an offender may say "Kṛṣṇa", but love works no change in him.[13]

25 "Alas, that heart is hard as stone which does not change when the names of Hari are chanted; for when the heart is changed, tears fill the eyes and the hairs of the body stand on end in joy." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.3.24)[14]

26 A single name of Kṛṣṇa destroys all sins and reveals devotion, from which love is born.[15]

27 When love dawns, its transformations appear: sweat and trembling, the hairs standing on end, a faltering voice and flowing tears.

28 Worldly existence ends without effort, and one is given the service of Kṛṣṇa: such is the wealth that a single name of Kṛṣṇa brings.

29–30 If one takes such a name of Kṛṣṇa again and again, and still no love comes and no tears flow, then I know that his offences are many: the seed of Kṛṣṇa's name does not sprout in him.[16]

31 With Caitanya and Nityānanda there is no such reckoning of offences: as soon as one takes Their names They give love, and streams of tears flow.[17]

32 The Lord is independent and supremely magnanimous; without worshipping Him there is never any deliverance.[18]

33 O foolish people, hear the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, and from it you will know all the glory of Caitanya![19]

34 Veda-vyāsa told the pastimes of Kṛṣṇa in the *Bhāgavata*; the Vyāsa of Caitanya's pastimes is Vṛndāvana dāsa.

35 Vṛndāvana dāsa composed the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, and by hearing it all that is inauspicious is destroyed.

36 In it one comes to know the glory of Caitanya and Nitāi, and in it I come to know the conclusions of devotion to Kṛṣṇa to their farthest limit.[20]

37 He understood the essence of all the conclusions of devotion in the *Bhāgavata*, drew it out and set it down in his book.

38 If even an unbeliever or a yavana hears the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, he becomes a great Vaiṣṇava at that very moment.

39 No human being could compose so blessed a book: it is Śrī Caitanya who speaks through the mouth of Vṛndāvana dāsa.

40 Millions of obeisances at the feet of Vṛndāvana dāsa! By writing such a book he delivered the world.

41 Nārāyaṇī partook of Caitanya's remnants, and from her womb Śrī Vṛndāvana dāsa was born.[21]

42 How wonderful is his description of Caitanya's deeds! By hearing it the three worlds were purified.

43 Therefore, O people, worship Caitanya and Nityānanda! The misery of worldly life will be cut away, and you will attain the bliss of love.

44 Vṛndāvana dāsa composed the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, and in it he told all the pastimes of Caitanya.

45 First he set down all the pastimes in a brief summary, and afterwards described them at length.

46 The pastimes of Caitanya-candra are endless and boundless, and as he went on describing them the book grew long.

47 Seeing its length, he grew somewhat hesitant, and some of the pastimes held in the summary he did not describe.[22]

48 He became absorbed in describing the pastimes of Nityānanda, and Caitanya's final pastimes were left untold.

49 The devotees of Vṛndāvana longed to hear the account of all those pastimes.

50 In Vṛndāvana, beneath a wish-fulfilling tree, stands a golden temple; there is the great Yogapīṭha, and in it a jewelled throne.

51 On it the son of the king of Vraja is ever seated: His name is Śrī Govinda-deva, the very God of love.

52 There He is served like a king in many wonderful ways, with divine offerings, divine garments and ornaments.

53 A thousand servants attend Him constantly; that service could not be described even with a thousand mouths.

54 The superintendent of that service is Śrī Haridāsa Paṇḍita, whose fame and virtues are known throughout the world.

55 He is gentle, patient, serene, generous and grave, sweet in speech and sweet in conduct, and steady beyond measure.

56 He honours everyone and works for the good of all; his heart is free of crookedness, envy and malice.

57 The fifty good qualities of Kṛṣṇa that are shared in part by others all dwell in his person.[23]

58 "In one whose devotion to the Lord is free of desire all the gods dwell, and with them every virtue. But how can great qualities be found in one who is not devoted to Hari? Driven by his desires, his mind is forever running outward after what is passing." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.18.12)[24]

59 Ananta Ācārya was the disciple of Paṇḍita Gosāñi; his very body was made of love for Kṛṣṇa, and he was generous and noble in every way.[25]

60 Who could recount his endless virtues? And this Haridāsa Paṇḍita is his dear disciple.

61 His faith in Caitanya and Nityānanda is boundless, and the deeds of Caitanya fill him with the greatest joy.

62 He takes in the virtues of the Vaiṣṇavas and never sees their faults; with body, mind and words he seeks to please them.

63 He listens constantly to the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, and by his grace all the Vaiṣṇavas hear it too.[26]

64 Like the full moon he lights up the assembly with his words, and with the nectar of his virtues he increases the joy of the Vaiṣṇavas.

65 Out of his great mercy he gave me the order to describe Gaurāṅga's final pastimes.

66 Govinda Gosāñi, the disciple of Kāśīśvara Gosāñi, is the dear servant of Govinda, and there is none to equal him.[27]

67 Yādavācārya Gosāñi, the companion of Śrī Rūpa, takes the greatest delight in Caitanya's deeds.

68 Bhūgarbha Gosāñi, the disciple of Paṇḍita Gosāñi, has nothing on his lips but talk of Gaura.

69 His disciples are Caitanya-dāsa, the priest of Govinda, Mukundānanda Cakravartī and Kṛṣṇadāsa, full of love.[28]

70 Śivānanda Cakravartī, the disciple of Ācārya Gosāñi, holds Śrī Caitanya and Nityānanda ever in his heart.[29]

71 And all the other devotees who live in Vṛndāvana wished to hear the final pastimes.

72 In their compassion they all gave me the order, and at their word I write, casting off all shame.

73 Having received the Vaiṣṇavas' order, I went with an anxious heart to Madana-gopāla to beg for His order too.[30]

74 When I had seen Him, I bowed at His feet; the pūjārī Gosāñi-dāsa was serving His feet.

75 When I begged at the Lord's feet for His order, the garland slipped from His neck and fell.[31]

76 All the Vaiṣṇavas cried out "Hari!", and Gosāñi-dāsa brought the garland and placed it around my neck.

77 Receiving the garland of His order, I was filled with joy, and then and there I began this book.

78 It is Madana-mohana who makes me write this book; my writing is like the recitation of a parrot.[32]

79 I write what Madana-gopāla makes me write, as a magician makes a wooden doll dance.

80 My family Deity is Madana-mohana, whose servants are Raghunātha, Rūpa and Sanātana.[33]

81 Meditating on the lotus feet of Vṛndāvana dāsa and taking his permission, I write what brings blessing.[34]

82 In the pastimes of Caitanya, Vṛndāvana dāsa is Vyāsa; without his mercy no one else can reveal them.

83 I am foolish, low and insignificant, greedy for the objects of the senses; it is by the strength of the Vaiṣṇavas' order that I make so bold.

84 This is the strength of the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, by remembering whom every desire is fulfilled.

85 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: by the will of Lord Caitanya-deva I, a fool like a painted puppet, have suddenly begun this dance of writing a book. *Anubhāṣya*: *jaḍaḥ* — "like one without sense"; *lekha-raṅge* — "in the play of composing this book"; *prasabham* — "suddenly". ↩
2. Edition heading to 6–8: "To worship Gaura or Kṛṣṇa without accepting the glory of the Pañca-tattva, with a mind that separates Them, is a grave offence." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *ei saba* — "this Pañca-tattva"; those who practise devotion to Kṛṣṇa without accepting it receive no mercy from Kṛṣṇa. ↩
3. Edition heading: "Devotion to Gaura without devotion to Kṛṣṇa, and devotion to Kṛṣṇa without devotion to Gaura, is not devotion." *Anubhāṣya*: Jarāsandha and the others worshipped Viṣṇu with Vedic mantras, but because they rejected Kṛṣṇa, the original Lord Himself, out of enmity or indifference, their worship ended in the dharma of the asuras. So too, when a jīva tries to worship Viṣṇu while forgetting his eternal service to Śrī Caitanya, that is only the same dharma of the asuras, not Vaiṣṇavism. ↩
4. *Anubhāṣya* to 10–11: Śrī Caitanya-candra is non-different from Śrī Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa. Seeing that people in their ignorance judged His pastimes by their own worldly attachments and could not understand Him, Śrī Gaurahari took the vow

of renunciation for their sake before the eyes of the world, and so showed mercy to the unwise. ↩

5. Edition heading: “Not to be devoted to the magnanimous Gaura is the nature of an asura.” *Anubhāṣya*: whoever cannot grasp even this mercy of Śrī Caitanya — His call to the jīvas, “Worship Kṛṣṇa” — is an asura, not a Vaiṣṇava, however much the world may honour him. Worship of Caitanya that rejects the worship of Kṛṣṇa lacks His mercy and is an invention of the age of Kali; it is just as asuric to revere one of the six truths while slighting another, or to see Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya as merely the best of mortals, different from Kṛṣṇa. ↩
6. Edition heading: “Gaura’s mercy is more wonderful than any other mercy.” *Anubhāṣya* to 14–15: logic rests on the worldly senses, which are weak and unfit to grasp the Lord, and so it often passes falsehood off as proven truth. Yet even one who relies only on perception and inference, if he compares every kind of mercy, will find that the mercy of Śrī Gaurahari is found in nothing created, nor in the Creator, nor in the avatāras, nor even in the Source of the avatāras, Kṛṣṇa. ↩
7. Edition heading: “While offences remain, countless hearing and chanting are fruitless.” *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: this is said of one who commits the ten offences against the holy name (see 8.24). *Anubhāṣya*: whoever hears and chants without taking shelter at Śrī Caitanya’s feet will not attain love for Kṛṣṇa even in many births; but whoever, following His teaching, is humbler than grass and more tolerant than a tree, seeks no honour and gives honour to others, is freed from the ten offences, chants the name constantly and attains prema. ↩
8. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: liberation comes easily through knowledge, and the pleasures of heaven through pious works, but devotion to Hari is not easily attained even by thousands of practices: something more is needed — service to a pure devotee and knowledge of one’s relationship with the Supreme Truth (*sambandha-jñāna*). The reference is confirmed by the edition. ↩
9. Edition heading: “Until *bhāva* (rati) has awakened in the jīva, Kṛṣṇa grants liberation; when He sees rati, He grants loving devotion.” *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: if devotees hope for enjoyment and liberation, Kṛṣṇa hides pure devotion from them, grants them these and leaves them (*chuṭe* — “goes away, leaving them”). ↩
10. *Anubhāṣya*: these are Śukadeva’s words to Parīkṣit in the account of Ṛṣabhadeva. *Daivam* — “the Deity you worship”; *priyaḥ* — “your very self”; *kva ca* — “sometimes, as when He acted as a messenger”; *bhajatām* — “to those who worship Him with desires (*sakāma-bhaktas*)”: to them He grants liberation, but He never gives bhakti-yoga. Edition heading: “Without a

relationship of rasa with Kṛṣṇa one gains only liberation." The edition misprints *kulavatiḥ*; the *Anubhāṣya* explains *kula-patiḥ*. ↩

11. *Anubhāṣya*: even sinners and wrongdoers like Jagāi and Mādhāi, once they receive Gaura's mercy, give up their sins and one day attain love for Kṛṣṇa. ↩
12. Edition heading to 22–23: "Love for Kṛṣṇa awakens through service to Gaura and Nitāi." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* to 21–22: the wonder of Śrī Caitanya's descent is that to anyone who comes near Him He, the independent Lord, gives the hidden storehouse of prema without asking whether he is worthy or not. Offender or not, whoever surrenders and calls on Him — "O Gaurāṅga! O Kṛṣṇa Caitanya!" — is overwhelmed with the thrills and tears of love for Kṛṣṇa. ↩
13. The *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* lists, after the *Padma Purāṇa*, the ten offences against the holy name: (1) blaspheming the saints; (2) thinking the names of Śiva and other gods independent of Viṣṇu; (3) disregarding the guru; (4) reviling the śruti and the scriptures that follow it; (5) thinking the glory of the name an exaggeration; (6) interpreting the name in one's own way, as a fancy; (7) sinning on the strength of the name; (8) equating the name with other pious acts; (9) instructing the faithless and the averse in the name; (10) having no love for the name even after hearing its glory. While these offences remain, Kṛṣṇa shows no mercy, and the offender has no true transformations of love. The *Anubhāṣya* explains each of them. ↩
14. *Anubhāṣya*: these are Śaunaka's words to Sūta. *Aśma-sāram* — a heart as hard as stone because of offences against the holy name. Yet the heart of a deep mahā-bhāgavata may melt at the name with no outward tears or thrills, while those who imitate for the sake of honour may show false tears and thrills without a trace of feeling; so a show of melting in beginners inclined to enjoyment, even when they chant the name abundantly, is itself a sign of offence. Edition heading: "Without the desire to please Kṛṣṇa, the feelings in an offender's stony heart are not pure; they are only an imitation." ↩
15. Edition heading: "The self-manifest Lord, the Name, rising on the tongue, bestows love for Kṛṣṇa." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the devotion that awakens prema is *sādhana-bhakti*; it is this that the holy name reveals. ↩
16. Edition heading to 29: "The countless hearing and chanting of one who offends the holy name are fruitless." ↩
17. Edition heading: "With Gaura and Nitāi, and with Their names, offences are not weighed." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: whoever takes shelter of Caitanya and Nityānanda with faith has his past offences washed away in a moment, and They give prema as soon as the name of Kṛṣṇa begins to rise on his lips.

Anubhāṣya: an offender who chants the name of Kṛṣṇa does not obtain the fruit of the name, prema; but one who chants the names of Gaura and Nityānanda, even while still an offender, is freed from offences in the very act of chanting and obtains that fruit. The name of Kṛṣṇa and the name of Gaura are equally non-different from the One they name; but Kṛṣṇa's magnanimity is shown to the liberated, while that of Gaura and Nityānanda reaches even those who still have *anarthas*. ↩

18. Edition heading: "There is no other way than to worship the magnanimous Gaura." *Anubhāṣya*: "worshipping Śrī Caitanya" does not mean worshipping Gaura while leaving aside Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa; those who bypass Svarūpa, Rūpa, Raghunātha and the other ācāryas closest to Śrī Caitanya and invent their own worship of Gaura are never delivered. ↩
19. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the *Caitanya-maṅgala* is the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* of Śrī Vṛndāvana dāsa Ṭhākura of the village of Denuḍ (Bardhamān district). The book was first called *Caitanya-maṅgala*; it is said that when Locana dāsa Ṭhākura began to sing his own *Caitanya-maṅgala*, Vṛndāvana dāsa renamed his book. Edition heading to 33–35: "The highest good of the jīva lies in hearing the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* of Ṭhākura Vṛndāvana dāsa, the incarnation of Vyāsa." ↩
20. *Anubhāṣya*: the *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* is the treasury of the conclusions of bhakti, but it is so vast that many cannot take in its essence; that essence Śrī Vṛndāvana dāsa Ṭhākura set down in his *Śrī Caitanya-bhāgavata*. Only those who know the conclusions of devotion can truly understand the glory of Nitāi-Gaura, for without right understanding (*siddhānta*) the goddess of Devotion cannot be served. ↩
21. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Nārāyaṇī was the daughter of Śrīvāsa Paṇḍita's brother; as a child she received the remnants of Mahāprabhu's meal after kīrtana. *Anubhāṣya*: in the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* Kavi-karṇapūra writes that Nārāyaṇī is Kilimbikā, the sister of Kṛṣṇa's nurse Ambikā, who ate Kṛṣṇa's remnants. Ṭhākura Vṛndāvana is known through his mother, who received Śrī Gaurasundara's remnants and mercy; his ancestry on his father's side is not given, for a Vaiṣṇava needs no introduction through his forefathers. ↩
22. Edition heading: "But for fear of enlarging the book he did not wish to expand the summary." ↩
23. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the fifty common qualities of Kṛṣṇa are listed in the *Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu* (Southern Division, First Wave: *ayaṁ netā suramyāṅgaḥ…*). ↩

24. *Anubhāṣya*: Śukadeva speaks these words to Parīkṣit while describing the qualities of the great devotee Prahlāda. *Akiñcanā* — "free of desire"; *samāsate* — "dwell eternally"; *asati* — "in the passing happiness of sense objects"; *mahad-guṇāḥ* — the virtues of the great, such as knowledge and detachment. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: in one who has pure devotion to Kṛṣṇa the gods abide with all their qualities; but the mind of one without devotion to Hari always runs after what is external and unreal, and great qualities are impossible for him. ↩
25. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *Paṇḍita Gosāñi* is Śrī Gadādhara Paṇḍita. *Anubhāṣya* to 59–60: in Gaura's pastimes Ananta Ācārya is Sudevī, one of the eight sakhīs of Vraja (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 165). From him comes the well-known Gaṅgāmātā Maṭha of Purī; in that line Ananta Ācārya is called Vinoda-mañjarī, and his disciple Haridāsa Paṇḍita (also called Raghu-gopāla) is Rāsa-mañjarī. Haridāsa's disciple was Lakṣmīpriyā, and hers Gaṅgāmātā, a daughter of the Rājā of Puṭiyā, who brought the Deity of Śrī Rasikarāya from Jaipur and established His service in the house of Sārvabhauma in Purī. ↩
26. Edition heading: "His reading of the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* in the assembly of Vaiṣṇavas." ↩
27. Edition heading to 66–72: "Who they were — the devotees who gave that same order." *Anubhāṣya*: Kāśīśvara (Paṇḍita) Gosvāmī was a disciple of Īśvara Purī. He was very strong: each day, when Mahāprabhu went to see Jagannātha, he walked ahead and cleared the way through the crowd, and in Purī he served prasāda to the devotees after kīrtana. In the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* he is Kṛṣṇa's servant Bhṛṅgāra in Vṛndāvana, or Śaśirekhā. ↩
28. *Anubhāṣya*: on Bhūgarbha see Ādi 12.81; on Śivānanda (8.70), Ādi 12.87. ↩
29. *Ācārya Gosāñi* — by the context (8.59–60), Ananta Ācārya; in Ādi 12.87 Śivānanda Cakravartī is counted in the branch of Gadādhara Paṇḍita. ↩
30. Edition heading: "Having received the Vaiṣṇavas' order, I beg in awe for the order of Śrī Madana-gopāla." ↩
31. Edition heading to 74–76: "As soon as the pūjārī Gosāñi-dāsa made the request, before all the Vaiṣṇavas the garland fell from Madana-gopāla — His order." ↩
32. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: what I have written in the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* was written by the inspiration of Śrī Madana-mohana; so, as with a parrot's recitation, none of the credit is mine. ↩
33. Edition heading: "Service to Madana-mohana in the author's line of gurus." ↩
34. Edition heading to 81–82: "The author, as befits a Vaiṣṇava, honours Ṭhākura Vṛndāvana dāsa as his guru and bows to him." ↩